helpful in developing that but must, in fairness, be set against the context of its era.

Since a fierce independence runs as a thread through our policy evolution, it is perhaps useful to begin with an updated understanding of what non-alignment was all about. Until the 1962 conflict, India's effort was to get the best from the two camps that the Cold War had created. It was successful in obtaining economic and food assistance from the West, while simultaneously seeking collaboration in industrialization from the Soviet bloc. For its security needs, India approached both with some success, eventually getting adequate capabilities from the USSR.

In different ways, China too attempted the same, although with greater ambition and less consistency. Indeed, the steadiness of one contrasted with the disruptiveness of the other. It is an open question whether one could have adopted the approach of the other; perhaps they were statements of their character. The middle path was not just a policy choice for India; it also reflected contradictory structural pulls. With the West, India was bound by a broad network of post-colonial economic, social and political linkages; but Cold War pressures prevented excessive closeness. With the USSR, the planned economy model and industrial aspirations generated an enthusiasm that was balanced against pluralistic political beliefs. As India went about the task of consolidating its national integration, both camps served its interests at different points of time. Most important, they helped expand its political space at a time when a large number of nations were regaining their freedom. This allowed India the leadership opportunity to build its own constituency and brand through the 1950s.

Broad concepts are not always easy to translate into policy, interests and outcomes. Non-alignment was no exception to the rule. India's engagement with the West was heavily Eurocentric and did not cater adequately for the new American primacy. This contrasted with the determined cultivation of the new superpower by the Pakistani elite. Differences with the US in the larger global arena also helped solidify American support for Pakistan, to a point where that country eventually reached a tactically superior position in 1965. At the other end, the political opening with the USSR provided early harvest, including support in the UN on Jammu and Kashmir. Its defence